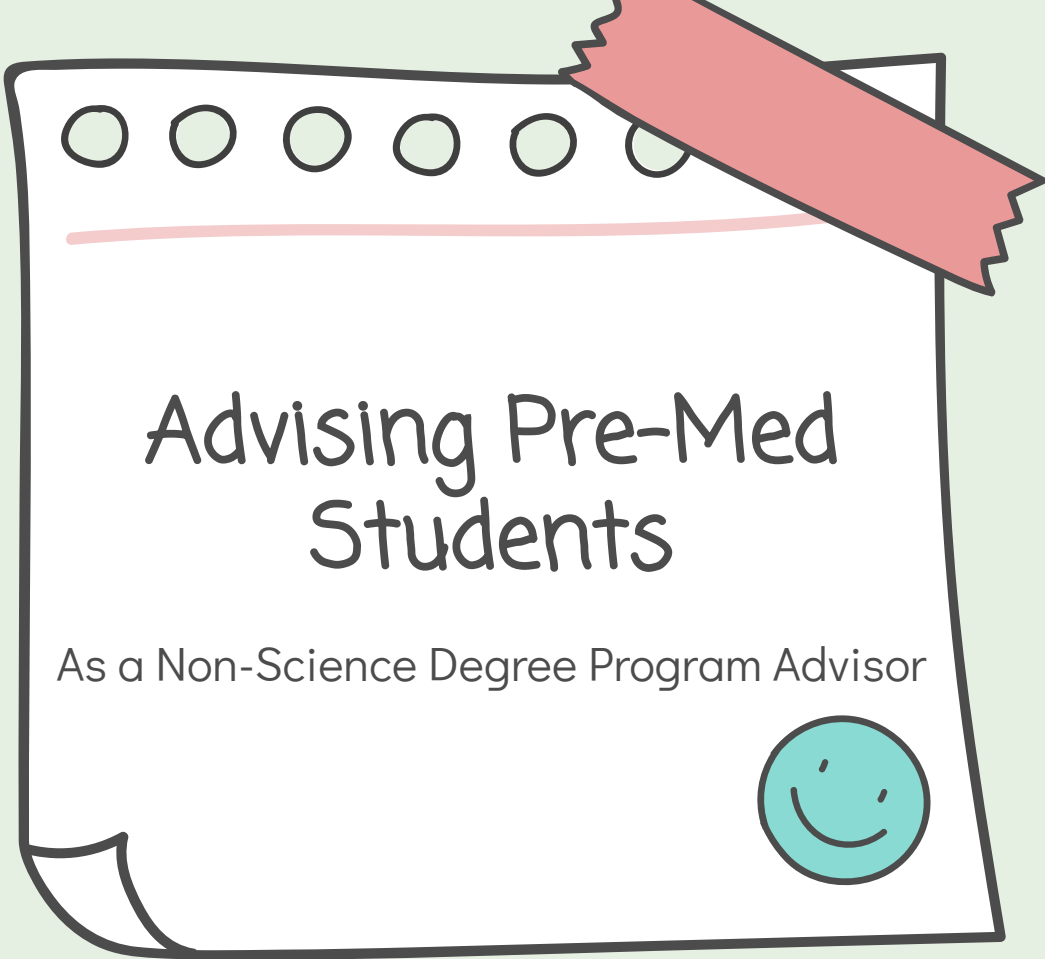


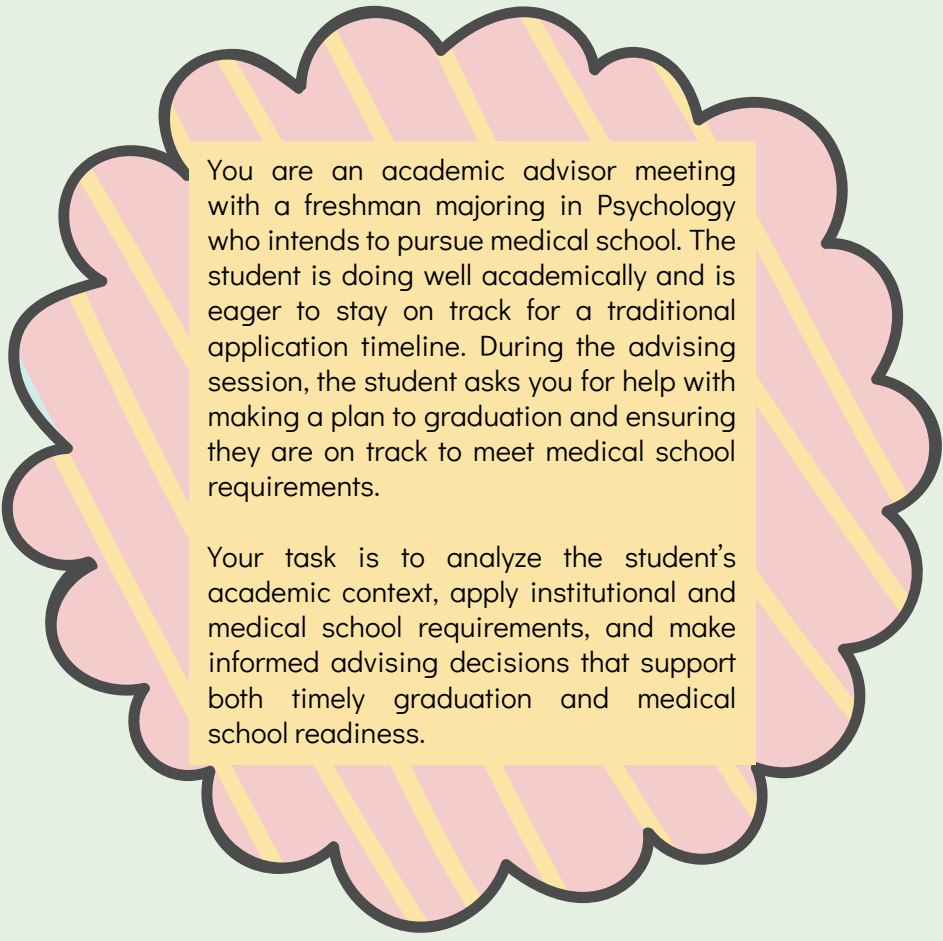


Advising Pre-Med Students

As a Non-Science Degree Program Advisor



GO!



You are an academic advisor meeting with a freshman majoring in Psychology who intends to pursue medical school. The student is doing well academically and is eager to stay on track for a traditional application timeline. During the advising session, the student asks you for help with making a plan to graduation and ensuring they are on track to meet medical school requirements.

Your task is to analyze the student's academic context, apply institutional and medical school requirements, and make informed advising decisions that support both timely graduation and medical school readiness.

[Next](#)

[Back](#)



Background Scenario

Let's Go!

When should I
refer students to
the pre-med
advisors?

How does GPA
factor into
advising
decisions for pre-
med students?

How can I ensure
the information
I'm telling
students is
correct?

How can I determine
the feasibility and
timeline for
integrating pre-med
courses into a
student's degree
plan?

Back

You should refer students to the pre-med advisors whenever their questions fall outside of your expertise!



Home

What is included
in the **academic**
advisor's scope
of practice?

What is included
in the **pre-med**
advisor's scope
of practice?



Home

How early is
too early to
refer students
to the pre-med
advisors?



Academic advisors are responsible for all of the **academic-related factors** involved in pre-med planning. This includes picking out the right courses, planning them in the right sequence, withdrawals/repeats, and GPA discussions.

What is included in the **academic advisor's** scope of practice?

Back



Home

How early is
too early to
refer students
to the pre-med
advisors?

Pre-med advisors are responsible for all the **non-academic components** of the pre-med track. This includes preparing for the MCAT, getting involved in shadowing/volunteering, etc. They can *help confirm* that prerequisites are being met, but that's primarily your job.

What is included in the pre-med
advisor's scope of practice?

Back



Home

Back



Never!

It's never too early to send a student to pre-med advising. You just need to make sure you're doing your part and not just passing everything off.

GPA is one of the most important factors of a med school application. Med programs will look at students' cumulative and Biology/Chemistry/Physics/Math (BCPM) GPAs.



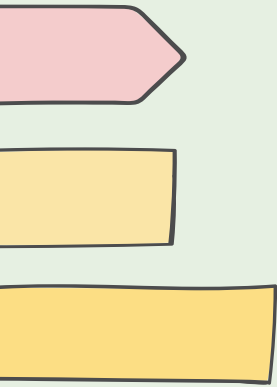
Home



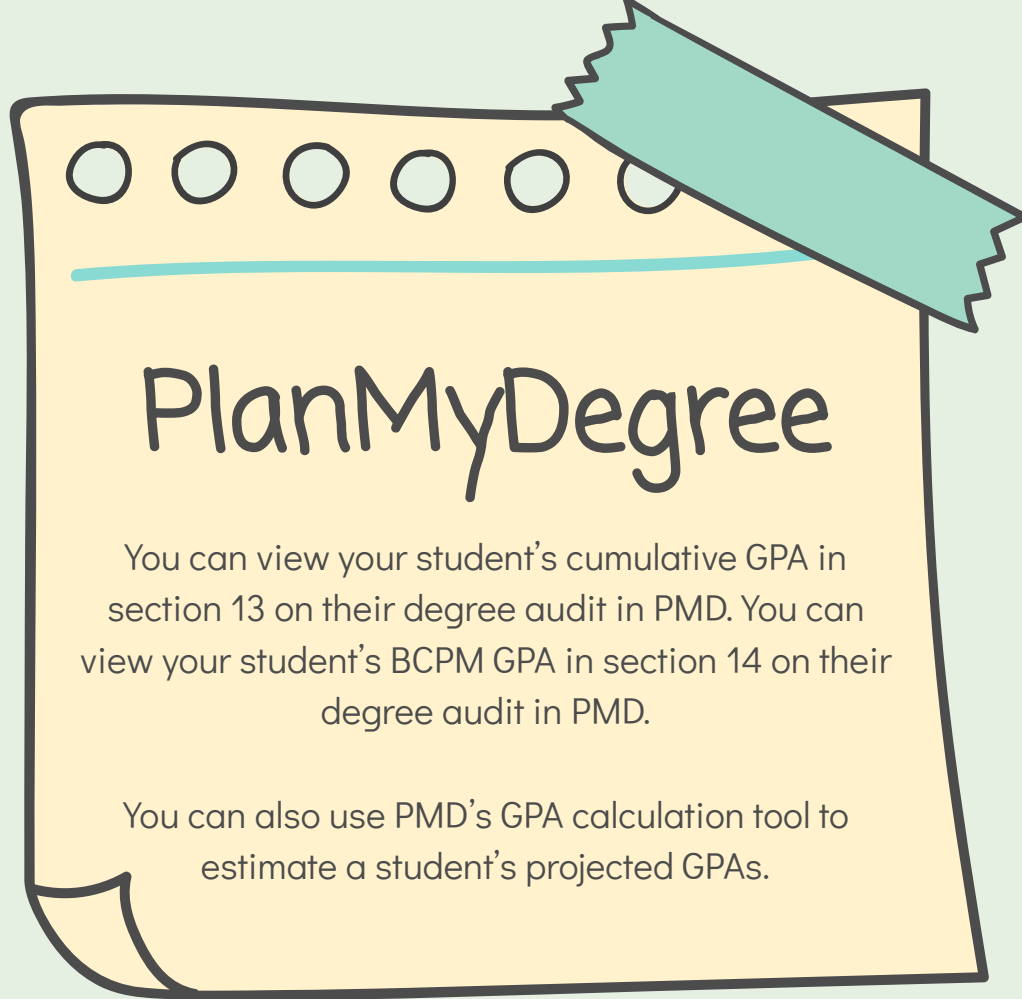
How can I check my
students' cumulative
and BCPM GPAs?



What is a
competitive GPA?



Back



PlanMyDegree

You can view your student's cumulative GPA in section 13 on their degree audit in PMD. You can view your student's BCPM GPA in section 14 on their degree audit in PMD.

You can also use PMD's GPA calculation tool to estimate a student's projected GPAs.



Home



Home

Competitive GPA

This will differ by school.

Generally, students should aim for a 3.5 GPA or higher to be considered a competitive applicant.

What if a student is struggling in a class?

Back



Home

If a student is struggling in a class...

It is your job to help the student consider their options moving forward.

The student can either:

- **Withdraw from the class** – this will protect their GPA but will show as a W on their transcript, which isn't ideal

- **Stay in the class and see how it goes** – sometimes this is necessary depending on the student's financial aid or visa status

How are repeated courses/GPA adjustments factored into students' GPAs?

Back



Home



This will depend on the school. Some schools will accept the highest grade, while others will average the grades out. If a student needs to retake a course, it's always best to submit a GPA adjustment whenever possible, to boost their "front page" GPA.

How are repeated courses/GPA adjustments factored into students' GPAs?

Back

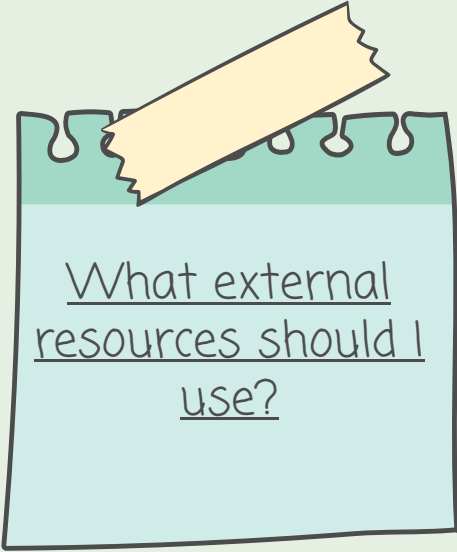
How can I ensure the information I'm telling students is correct?

- *Use the information presented in this module as a starting point!*
- *There are lots of internal and external resources available for you to reference. Which ones you use will depend on what questions your students have, but it's important to know where you can find these resources.*
- *You are also encouraged to sign up for a cross-training time with one of our pre-med advisors!*

Home



What internal
resources do we
have?



What external
resources should I
use?



Sign up for pre-
med cross-
training [HERE!](#)

The best internal resources you can use are the pre-med advising site and the pre-med advisors.



Home

[Pre-Med Advising
Website](#)

When should I refer
students to the pre-
med advisors?

Back



Home

External Resources

The best external resources you should reference are medical school admission pages and the [AAMC website!](#)

What external resources are less reliable?

Back



Home

Less Reliable Resources



Reddit

Can provide great info on personal questions/scenarios, but it isn't coming from official sources



Google AI overview

You need to verify the information is correct



Websites trying to sell a product or service

May have accurate info but may have ulterior motives

Back

Make a tentative plan in PMD that shows all the necessary major- and pre-med- courses.

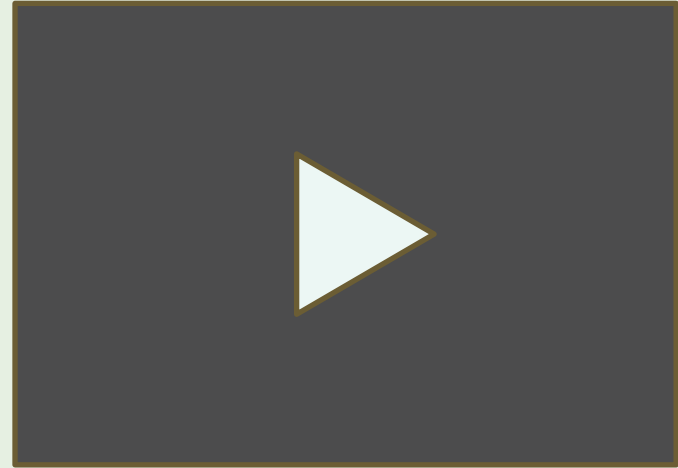
Pay attention to course sequencing/pre-requisites, and course loads.



Home

What factors
may impact
the
plan/timeline?

What
tradeoffs may
be necessary?



Watch this tutorial for creating a pre-med plan in PMD



Home

Major classes, full-time vs part-time, summer classes, other majors/minors, course loads can all impact the timeline.

1



What pre-med classes are required/recommended?

2



Which pre-med courses must be taken in sequence?

3



What's a recommended course load?

Back

What pre-med classes are required? What pre-med classes are recommended?



Home

Required

Depends on school. Classes required for MCAT include organic chemistry (gen chem), physics (math), biochem (cell and gen chem), physiology (cell).

Check out school admission websites for specific requirements

Recommended

Genetics, anatomy, micro, histology, psychology, sociology, upper-level bio classes.

Back



Home

Course Sequencing

General bio/general chem → cell/organic chemistry/genetics →
biochem/physiology

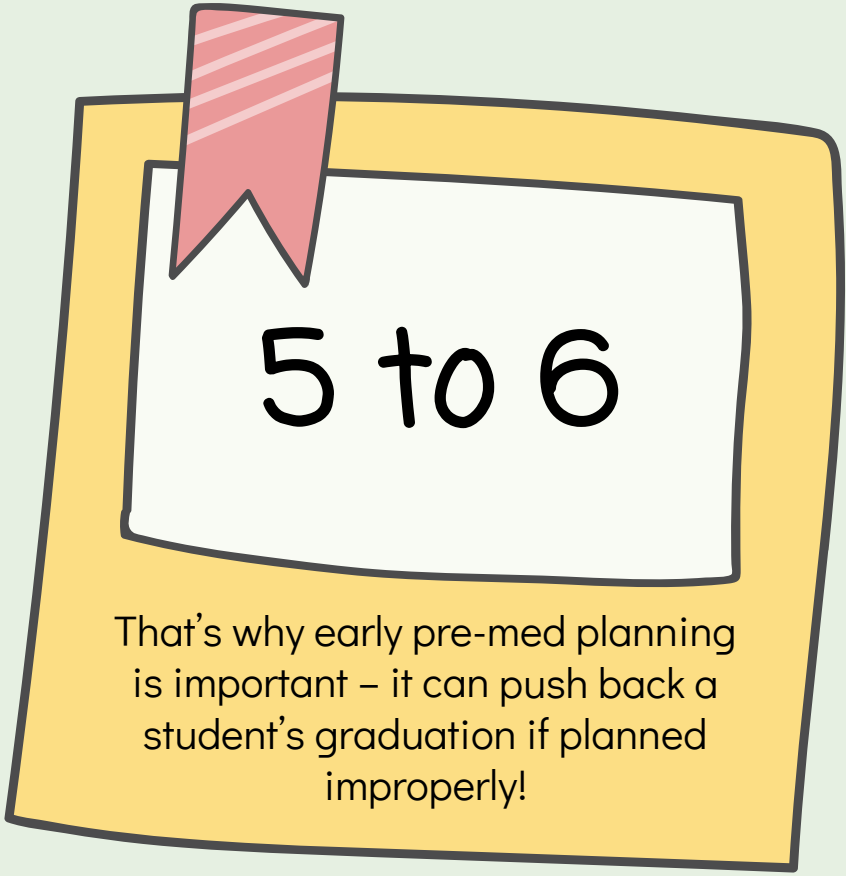
Refer to plan my degree and course catalog for pre-requisites if
not memorized

How many semesters are typically
required to complete the sequence?

Back



Home



5 to 6

That's why early pre-med planning
is important – it can push back a
student's graduation if planned
improperly!

Back



Home

Course Load

Depends somewhat on the student (work schedule, finances, etc.).

Recommend at least 15-16 credits each semester (if possible) to show they can handle heavier course loads.

Don't exceed 17 without prior approval.

Try to maintain balance between STEM and non-STEM courses.

Back



Home

What tradeoffs may be necessary?

Summer classes, extending graduation,
reducing minors (if applicable), heavier
course loads, gap year

How should gap years
be handled?

Back



Wow!



Home

Back



*There's nothing
wrong with a gap
year!*

They make a lot of sense for some
people.

It's important to keep working,
learning, volunteering – keep
building application (it's not a
vacation)



Home

Thanks!

Do you have any questions?

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816-235-1148



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